

The Wurm That Devoured Heaven

Book One — The Runt and the Word

Chapter Three

A Name He Chose

She noticed on the fourth day.

Vale had begun to think she wouldn't. Three days had passed since Ruun went into the crack, and the mother had not once stopped to ask herself why there were now four hatchlings in the nest instead of five. Mothers, in Vale's old life, had been people who knew where their children were at all hours, who felt the absence of a child the way a person feels the absence of a tooth. He had assumed dragon mothers were the same.

He had been wrong. Or rather — and this was the more interesting answer — dragon mothers were the same, but slower.

On the fourth day she stirred from her usual position and did something she hadn't done before. She lowered her huge head into the heap of sleeping hatchlings and, one at a time, breathed on each of them. Long slow exhalations, hot from her nostrils, that woke each child in turn and

made it scrabble against the warmth and chirp.

She breathed on the bronze one. She breathed on each of the near-twins. She breathed on the far one.

She did not breathe on Ruun, because Ruun was no longer there to breathe on.

She paused.

Vale, in the shell-shadow, kept his breathing shallow and his good eye half-closed. He held the slate dark. He held the warm thing in his throat *down*. He had practiced for this. He had been practicing for this for three days.

The mother's great head moved across the heap, counting. Her head moved across the heap a second time, counting again. She made a low rumbling noise that wasn't quite a word and wasn't quite a question.

Then her enormous eye — the one on his side of her face — rolled toward him.

He kept the breathing shallow.

He kept everything shallow.

He felt her attention settle on him the way a hand settles on a chess piece a player isn't sure they want to move. He felt her consider him. He

felt her consider, also, the crack at the far edge of the nest — her gaze moved that way too, just for an instant, with the slow uneasy calculation of an animal that has almost noticed a thing.

He kept the breathing shallow.

Her gaze came back to him. It stayed on him for a slow count of ten. Then she did something Vale would think about for a long time afterward, in many quiet hours of his life.

She blew on him too.

A long warm exhalation, almost gentle, sweet with the smell of old blood and char. He scrabbled in the warmth, on cue. He chirped, on cue. He let his small wet body roll into the warm draft with the bonelessness of a thing that has no plans of its own.

The mother made a low sound that might have been a sigh.

Then she withdrew her head, and curled herself back into a ring around the nest, and went back to sleep.

The slate did not chime. The slate did not say anything at all.

Vale lay in the warm draft and thought, with a clarity that almost surprised him:

She knows.

She knows one of them is gone. She might know which one. She might even know it was me.

But she does not care enough to do anything about it.

He turned the thought over and decided, in his old strategist's way, that there were three possible reasons for that. One: she had already written Ruun off as the second-weakest and accepted his death as nest economy. Two: she was, for reasons of her own, uninterested in adjudicating the deaths of her own children. Three: she had calculated that the runt who survived the strong child was, on net, the more interesting investment.

He couldn't tell which it was. He suspected it might be a mixture of all three.

He filed all three, separately, and then he filed a fourth thing too. A small uncomfortable thing he hadn't expected to feel.

She blew on me.

She had never done that before.

He did not know what to do with that information. He decided to do nothing with it for the moment, and to come back to it when he had room.

On the fifth day, the bronze one almost killed him.

It wasn't deliberate. That was the worst part. The bronze one had no plan for him. The bronze one was simply going to eat. Vale was simply going to eat. Both of them, on the fifth day, wanted the same piece of the carcass — a wild boar this time, smaller than the deer, with a smell that brought all four remaining hatchlings out of sleep before the mother had even set it down.

Vale, in keeping with his three-day-old strategy, went for the underside.

The bronze one, in keeping with what Vale would later understand was simply the bronze one's nature, went for everything at once.

They met under the boar's ribcage.

The bronze one's head came up through a gap in the meat with a mouthful of liver and saw Vale, two inches away, with his own mouthful of belly-fat. For one half-second they stared at each other in the wet red dark of the carcass. The bronze one swallowed.

The bronze one bit at him.

Vale, with the speed of a sibling not his own, was no longer there.

It happened so fast he didn't decide to do it. The new instinct in his hind legs — Ruun's instinct, the *knowing* the slate had put in his muscles — fired without him. He was on his side, then on his belly, then

six feet away, then under the tail of the carcass, then up against the mother's flank, panting.

The bronze one stood in the middle of the wreckage with its jaw still open around the empty space where Vale had been.

It looked, for a moment, confused.

Then it looked at Vale, against the mother's flank, with very different eyes than it had ever looked at him before.

The slate did not need to tell him what had just happened. He could feel it. Three days ago, the bronze one had dismissed him as meat. Today the bronze one had registered him as a thing that moved faster than a runt should move.

You showed it, Vale thought, at himself. You used the skill in front of the witness you wanted to keep using it on. The slate warned you. The slate was very clear.

You panicked.

He hated himself for it, briefly, with the cold professional self-hatred he had once reserved for the mornings after bad trades. Then he set the self-hatred aside and went back to thinking, because self-hatred had never made him a single dollar and there was no reason to believe it would do anything useful now.

The bronze one was watching him.

The bronze one would now think about him.

He had bought Ruun's death cheaply. He had paid much more for the bronze one's attention.

⌘ STATUS WARNING ⌘

[FEIGN WEAKNESS] Rank 1 / 5

Effective on Observer 1 (bronze line):

DEGRADED.

Observer has updated its model of you.

Estimated time to recovery of effect
on Observer 1: Never.

Note: Once a predator sees, it cannot
be unseen. Plan for the predator that
knows what you are.

He read it. He didn't argue. The slate was right.

The slate, he was beginning to learn, was almost always right.

⌘ ⌘ ⌘

That night — the night of the fifth day, the night of his almost-death by liver — the slate did something new.

He had curled himself as far from the bronze one as the nest permitted. He had eaten enough boar to feel slow and warm. He had been replaying the carcass moment in his head with the slow patient critique he had once applied to losing chess games. He was on the verge of sleep when the slate, very politely, lit up.

⌘ **UNLOCK — STAT ALLOCATION** ⌘

Condition met: You have survived a witness.

You now have access to manual stat allocation.

FREE STAT POINTS: 5

Spend on: VIT, STR, AGI, END, INT, WIS, WORD.

Costs scale per stat tier. Below 20: 1 pt = 1.

20-39: 1 pt = 0.5. 40+: 1 pt = 0.25.

WORD: cannot be raised by free points.

gained only through use.

(Welcome to the part of being a person where
you get to choose what kind of person you
are. Spend wisely.)

Vale stared at the page.

His brain, for one bright moment, ran exactly the way it had run in a boardroom — every option open, every option weighed against every

other, his old instinct for capital allocation firing on a problem it understood for the first time since the wine.

Five points, he thought.

He could put all five into AGI. He would be faster than any hatchling in the nest. He could escape. He could probably evade the bronze one for as long as he stayed in the nest.

He could put all five into STR. He could finally have claws and a bite that mattered. He could meet the bronze one on something closer to even terms.

He could put all five into VIT or END. He could survive longer without food, take a hit, sustain damage.

He could put all five into INT or WIS. He could think faster, see farther, read the slate deeper.

He thought about it for a long time. He thought about it with the slow patience of a man who had once held money in a market for thirteen years before he was willing to spend it.

He had two stats already higher than the others, by gift of his title: INT 19 and WIS 18. He could keep stacking those. Or he could shore up his catastrophic weaknesses — STR 2, VIT 4 — and bring himself closer to a balanced sheet.

He had a third option, and after a long minute it was the one he liked.

He had been thinking about the slate's tier rule. *Below 20: one point equals one. Twenty to thirty-nine: one point equals half.* That meant his next point in INT or WIS would be worth half what a point in STR or VIT was worth. He was looking at a tax on his strongest assets.

He had spent his old life avoiding taxes.

One in INT, he thought, very deliberately. To bring it to twenty exactly, before the tax kicks in. Then two in STR, two in VIT. Don't be clever. Don't try to win the next fight. Try to stop dying every six minutes.

He let the choices land on the slate.

⌘ **ALLOCATION CONFIRMED** ⌘

+1 INT (19 → 20. Tier shift on next point.)

+2 STR (2 → 4)

+2 VIT (4 → 6)

FREE STAT POINTS: 0 / 0

Allocation tip: You spent points on survival instead of on advantage. This is the choice of a man who has been killed before.

Noted.

He read the tip line twice.

The slate has opinions, he thought.

The slate is reading me.

He had assumed, in some part of his back-brain, that the slate was a passive interface — a heads-up display that printed messages from somewhere else. He was beginning to suspect it was more than that. The slate had a voice. The slate had a personality. The slate had, just now, just barely, sounded *impressed*.

He filed that observation in a slot of its own.



It happened on the seventh day.

He had grown. He had been growing since the boar; the +2 VIT had given him something his body could turn into mass, and he had spent every meal since then putting it on. He was no longer the length of a forearm. He was the length of a man's whole arm now, shoulder to fingertip, and his head — which had been the size of a plum a week ago — was the size of an apple. His scales had begun to harden along his spine and across the ridges above his eyes. His teeth had finished coming in.

He was, for the first time in his second life, dangerous to something. Not the bronze one. Not the near-twins, who outweighed him three to one. But there were things in the world smaller than a man's arm. He could feel that now in the way his jaw wanted to close, in the way his back legs wanted to chase, in the way his eyes — both of them now — tracked moving things without him asking them to.

He had become, in seven days, a small predator.

The slate noticed it before he did.

⌘ STAGE THRESHOLD ⌘

Current stage: 0 — HATCHLING.

Threshold: Met.

Conditions satisfied:

- ⌘ Body mass crossed minimum.
- ⌘ First kill recorded.
- ⌘ First Devour integrated.
- ⌘ First skill earned.
- ⌘ Survived seventh day.

EVOLUTION AVAILABLE.

[Stage 1: LESSER WYRMLING]

Branch: Bronze-line (default).

Branch: Ashen-line (recessive — unlocks
at Stage 2).

[ACCEPT] evolution costs 1 day of stillness.

you will not be able to move.

you will not be able to wake.

your siblings will be able to

see this happening.

[DECLINE] remain a hatchling. Stat caps
will apply. You will not grow
again at this stage.

Vale read the page slowly.

Then he read it again.

One day of stillness, he thought. In a nest with the bronze one. Who now knows what I am. Who has been thinking about me for two days.

And the alternative is staying a hatchling forever.

He understood — the way he had understood, in his old life, that the worst time to make a major move was always the time you felt most safe — that the slate was offering him a window. Evolutions happened. The first one was non-negotiable. The day of stillness was the cost the universe charged for changing what you were. Refusing it meant refusing growth. Refusing growth meant, eventually, being eaten by something that had not refused.

He had to take it. He just couldn't take it here.

He looked at the small cave-mouth on the far wall. The one with the long inhale and the short exhale. The one he had been marking, in the

corner of his head, since the second day.

It was a long way across the nest.

It was a long way across the nest *past* the bronze one.

He thought about it for a long time. The slate did not press him. The slate did not, in fact, do anything. It sat at the back of his head with the patience of a thing that had nothing but time.

He thought about Ruun's last sound.

He thought about the mother's slow breath on him on the fourth day.

He thought about the man he had been, in the wine, in the fortieth year of his life, looking across a table at a brother who had decided to inherit him.

Then he thought, very quietly, in a voice that was almost his old voice and almost something else now:

I have never refused growth in my life. I'm not starting now.

I just have to be somewhere else when it happens.

☒ ☒ ☒

He chose his moment carefully.

The mother left at what he was calling midmorning, with one long unhurried look at the heap of hatchlings and one long unhurried look at the cave-mouths. Then she was gone. The bronze one was asleep. The near-twins were asleep. The far one was asleep. The nest was the closest thing to safe it had been in seven days.

Vale, who had been crouched at the edge of the heap for an hour waiting for this exact configuration, moved.

He moved on the new legs Ruun had given him. He moved low and fast and quiet, in a line that ran along the curve of the nest-rim and then down the slope of the cave floor toward the small mouth in the far wall. He did not look at the bronze one. He did not pause. He did not breathe more than he had to.

The slate, very faintly, hummed in approval. He didn't have time to read what it said. He'd read it later.

Halfway to the cave-mouth, the bronze one's eye opened.

He registered it as a glint, in the corner of his good eye, as he passed. The bronze one was watching him go. The bronze one was not, however, moving. The bronze one was, he understood with the part of him that had read men for a living, *letting* him go.

You're hoping I leave, Vale thought, as his small body carried him across the last twenty feet of stone. *You'd rather one less mouth in the*

nest than the trouble of killing me. You're a fine economist for a creature with no thumbs.

He reached the cave-mouth.

He paused at the lip, only because he had to. The slate had been telling him, in small ways, for the last hour, that the evolution was about to start. He could feel it in his joints. He could feel it as a slow warm building *change* in the marrow of his small bones. If he went into the cave and the evolution caught him on a narrow ledge, he would fall.

He had to go in deep enough to be hidden and shallow enough to be safe.

He went in.



The passage was narrow and warm. It sloped down at a gentle angle for what felt like a very long time. The air inside it moved against his face the way the slate had described — long inhale, short exhale — and after what he estimated as about forty paces, the passage widened into a small side-chamber that had clearly been used by something, once, as a den. Old hair. Old bone. No smell of recent use.

He curled himself into the deepest corner of it. He pressed himself against stone.

I'm ready, he told the slate.

The slate said: *No, you aren't. But you're as ready as you get.*

Then it started.

The first thing he felt was his bones.

He hadn't known, until that moment, that bones could feel. They could. His bones felt like long iron rods being heated from the inside by something patient and uncaring. They felt like they were going to glow. They felt like they were going to *melt*. Then they felt like they were stretching, every bone at once, pulled by something that wasn't strength but was the slow honest force of a thing that had decided he would be bigger now.

He couldn't move. He couldn't make a sound. He couldn't even close the eye that was open.

He could feel his ribs widening. He could feel his spine lengthening, one vertebra at a time, with a sound that he heard only because his ear was pressed against stone and the stone carried it: a wet careful *tock, tock, tock*. He could feel his skull plates separating along their seams and rebuilding themselves wider, and the teeth in his jaw — which had only just finished coming in — pushing themselves out by their roots and being replaced from below by something larger.

His skin split.

Not in a wound. In a molt. The old hatchling skin, dull bronze and pale-stripe, sloughed off him in long ribbons as he grew out of it, and underneath was something new and wet and dark that he couldn't see but could feel: harder, ridged, properly scaled at last. He felt new claws push out through the soft tips of his old ones, and the old ones come away in his sleep like fingernail clippings.

He felt the wings.

He felt them *most* of all. They had been folded against his back for a week, vestigial, no bigger than playing cards. Now they unfurled inside their own pockets of new skin, and as they unfurled they pushed against the inside of him in ways that had not yet been allowed for. He felt the bones of the wing-fingers extend. He felt the membrane stretch. He felt, with a particular bright agony, the wing-shoulder muscles knit themselves into his back along new attachment points, drawing anchor lines along his spine and his ribs that he had not had an hour ago.

Somewhere inside the storm of it, he had a coherent thought.

This is what every dragon goes through.

Every single one. Every brother that survives the nest. Every stage. Every time.

No wonder they're so mean.

Then he passed out. The slate, gentle for the first time, made the lights go out for him.



He woke a very long time later, in the dark.

He didn't know how long. The slate, when he asked, said *twenty-six hours*. Longer than the contracted day; the slate added, by way of explanation, that he had been small and the body had needed extra time.

He moved one of his hands.

It moved differently.

He moved his tail.

It was longer. Heavier. He felt the weight of it across the stone behind him in a way he hadn't felt before, and felt — this was the strangest part — a sense of where the tip of it was, the way a man feels where his hand is even when his eyes are closed.

He moved his head, very carefully, and looked at himself.

His scales were no longer dull bronze. They were dark, almost black, with a hot reddish undertone where the coal-light caught them. The

pale stripe down his spine, which had been the only interesting feature of his old skin, was now a band of grey-white running unbroken from the base of his neck to the tip of his tail. His head was longer in the snout. His jaw was wider. His teeth — when he experimentally opened his mouth — were a full set of curved white things that looked, to his slow appreciation, like a row of small knives.

And he had wings.

They were small, still. Half-folded against his back. But they were no longer the leathery playing-card stubs of yesterday. They were thin and dark and ribbed, and when he flexed his back the membrane shifted with a soft dry sound that he understood, the way one understands a new instrument, would one day be the sound of him moving through air.

Not yet. Not for a long time. But one day.

The slate, for the first time since the egg, gave him a full page.

☒ **STAGE 1 — LESSER WYRMLING** ☒

Name: Ashk (the name another gave you.)

Race: Dragon — Lesser Wyrmling.

Subtype: Bronze-line (default branch).

Recessive Ashen marker: unchanged.

Age: 8 days. Mass: ~9 lb.

VIT: 14 (6 ☒ 14)

STR: 10 (4 ☒ 10)

AGI: 12 (6 ☒ 12)

END: 12 (3 ☒ 12)

INT: 22 (20 ☒ 22)

WIS: 20 (18 ☒ 20)

WORD: 1 (still sealed. for now.)

FREE STAT POINTS: 3

SKILLS:

[Feign Weakness] Rank 1 / 5 (degraded
against Observer 1 — permanent)

[Silent Footfall] Rank 1 / 5 (new)

TITLES:

[Soul Out Of Place]

[The Unburnt Who Took a Brother]

[Lesser Wyrmling — Survivor of the Nest]

DEVOUR SLOTS: 1 / 2 (+1 slot at this stage)

WORDS HELD: 1 / 2 (+1 slot at this stage)

He read every line.

He read [Survivor of the Nest] three times, and felt nothing in particular. The slate awarded titles, he was learning, for facts. He was alive. He had crossed a threshold. The slate did not love him for it. The slate, properly understood, did not love anything.

He liked it for that.

He spent his three free points the way a man tips after the service is over: +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 END. Survival, again. The slate said nothing about it this time. The slate had said its piece on his strategy two days ago. The slate was, he was beginning to understand, a careful spender of words.

☒ ☒ ☒

He lay in the dark of the small den for what felt like another hour. He let the new body settle. He flexed each new claw, one at a time, learning

the order of them. He moved his jaw. He tasted the air with a tongue that, somewhere in the storm, had split at the tip.

Then he thought about his name.

The slate, three weeks of life ago, had given him a piece of advice in his very first naming page, and he had filed it but not yet acted on it. *A name given by another is not yours. A name you choose is. Remember this.*

He had been called Ashk for seven days, and Ashk meant *leftover* and *cold remnant of fire*, and he had carried it the way a man carries a stone in his shoe — knowing it was there, choosing not to take it out yet because he was still walking to the place where he would sit down and remove it.

He was sitting down now.

He thought about his old name. Vale Corren. Vale had been a man's name; a man's last name; a man's father's last name; a name that belonged to a person he wasn't going to be again. He could keep it for himself, in the privacy of his head — and he did, would always — but he didn't want to wear it out here. It belonged to the dead.

He needed something new. Something short. Something his own.

He thought about the names the mother had used. Long round low syllables for the favored — heavy rolling sounds, mother-words, the kind of names that stayed in the throat of the room after she spoke them. Short flat exhaled words for the runts. He didn't want any of those. He didn't want anything that sounded like her language. Her language had given him Ashk, and Ashk was a word she had spat at him.

He wanted something from his own mouth.

He thought about the warm thing in his throat. The sealed Word. The thing the slate had told him was his own, locked up where no one could touch it, waiting for him to learn how to open it. He didn't know what his Word was. He wouldn't, the slate had implied, for some time. But it was in there. It was the irreducible piece of himself that nothing in this world had given him. It had come with the soul. It was his.

He thought about what sound a name like that would make.

Short. One syllable. From the throat, where the Word lived. Something he could speak even in the privacy of his head and feel right when he said it.

He tried, in the dark, the small sounds of his new mouth.

Veyr.

He stopped. He turned it over.

Veyr.

It sat in the back of his throat like a small warm coin. It had an edge to it — the *v* sharp at the front, the *r* trailing like smoke. It wasn't a mother-word. It wasn't a man-word. It belonged to nothing he had yet been.

He spoke it once, aloud, into the small dark den.

Veyr.

The cave did not shake. The slate hummed.

☒ NAMING — SELF ☒

You have given yourself a name.

NAME: Veyr.

Origin: Self-assigned.

Meaning: (yours to decide.)

TITLE acquired: [The Self-Named]

Effect 1: [Soul Out Of Place] effect 2

(interface in language of origin)

expands: System interface will now

speak to you in your new name's

voice as well.

Effect 2: The name [Ashk] is now a mask.

You may still answer to it. It can

no longer reach the part of you that

it was meant to wound.

Effect 3: When the time comes for your Word

to be heard, those who hear it will

hear it spoken by a Veyr, not an Ashk.

(This is a small thing. This is the only
thing of yours that is yours. Carry it.)

He read it. He read it twice.

Then, in the dark of the small den at the end of a passage in a cave he did not yet know the name of, on a continent he did not yet know the name of, in a world whose gods had walked away and left their power in the bones of the ground, the thing that had been Vale Corren and had been called Ashk by a mother who did not want him —

— became Veyr.

He flexed his new claws once, gently, against the stone of the den. The slate dimmed itself in the manner of a butler stepping out of a room. The slate, he had learned, did its best work when no one was watching.

Veyr — a small dragon, dark-scaled now, with a grey-white stripe and the beginnings of wings he could not yet use and an eight-day-old body that had killed once already — looked toward the slope of the passage. He could see, very faintly, the warm glow of the cavern beyond, the heat of the nest, the shape of the life he had just outgrown.

He turned away from it.

He turned the other way.

The small passage, the one that breathed long and exhaled short, went somewhere. He didn't know where. He didn't need to. He had a body now, and a name, and three points of survival in his ledger, and the slate at the back of his head, and the warm sealed Word in his throat, and a memory of his mother's slow breath on him on the fourth day.

He had everything he needed to find out what came next.

Veyr put one new claw forward into the dark of the passage, and then the other, and then his whole new body, and went.

— end of chapter —